

Stress Timing

There are two classes of words content words and grammatical words, content words are stressed e.g. main verbs, nouns, adjectives and adverbs while grammatical words are unstressed in sentences e.g. pronouns prepositions, conjunctions, articles and some auxiliary verbs.

Stress timing can be defined as the distribution of stressed and unstressed words in a sentence to produce a regular rhythm in English Language. It is having a rhythm in which stressed syllables tend to occur at regular intervals of time regardless of the number of intervening unstressed syllables.

Examples

1. The **SHORT** **BLACK** **GIRL** **KILLED** the **DOG**.
2. Let's **HAVE** **FISH** for a **CHANGE**.
3. They've Got a **BOY** and a **GIRL**
4. **ONE** **WAS** **TALLER** than the **REST**
5. **WHAT** **DO** their **PARENTS** **THINK**?

Stress timing can help to communicate meaning because the way the sentence is said can affect meaning.

Examples.

1. I asked you to buy me a bunch of red roses.
2. I asked **YOU** to buy me a bunch of red roses.
3. I asked you to buy me a bunch of **RED** roses.
4. I asked you to buy me a bunch of red **ROSES**.

